Keeping aside the collective joke at my expense (which earned me the moniker ‘Den Mother’), our duties were far from over. After the announcements, our team had to convert the pass-issuing station into a temporary cloakroom. We had to collect everyone’s luggage, issue tags and make sure each bag was loaded on to trucks that would ferry them to wherever we were to halt at night. Only when all this was done did we finally get to have breakfast and join the Yatra.

Walking the entire day in scorching heat was difficult, but unlike the other yatris (who had the small luxury of resting after they had walked the 25 kilometres), we had no rest. Our real jobs began once the Yatra was completed. Each of the camps was located about 20–30 kilometres from any town or water source. So one of our first duties was to arrange for a minimum of six water tankers for every camp per night! We had to also arrange for a generator to load this water into the washrooms and mobile toilets. On one particular night halt, we realized that we had sufficient water tankers but the generator van had abruptly vanished. We stayed up the whole night waking up people and begging them to lend us a generator, just so the yatris could resume the padyatra.

Another problem that cropped up was that after two districts, because of some miscommunication, fresh passes were printed by the leaders in charge of those districts. We could have continued with the earlier passes, but unfortunately the police had already been briefed about the revised passes. So on the fourth day of the Yatra, we again had to take back all the passes issued and reissue them afresh. This was completely avoidable, and just reinforces the earlier point I was making about the need for streamlined communication.

But I think this was still manageable. What was especially problematic was the disruptive elements within civil society. While an overwhelming majority of the civil society yatris was considerate, eager and helping us in this great adventure, a few disruptive elements began misbehaving with others. They reportedly began forcing younger civil society yatris to carry their bags, get them food and massage their legs. Over two dozen yatris complained about this organization to me. When I flagged this to other